THE NORTH WOODS, CURTIS & THE PACK

Active: Day 10+ (pack territory accessible) **Curtis Encounter:** Night 20 — automatic if Marcus is in north woods **Pack Membership:** Optional path following Curtis confrontation

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FINDING THE PACK — Three Entry Paths

PATH 1 — The Compass

Requires JACOB_COMPASS_FOUND

The compass drifts at night. Marcus has noticed it — the needle pulling north-northwest at odd hours, toward something that isn't magnetic north. Each night in the north woods following the drift takes him deeper. The territory shifts around him, time moving at its particular wrong pace. But the compass holds true when nothing else does.

On the fourth night following the drift he crests a shallow rise in the land and stops.

Below him — firelight. Not one fire. Several, arranged in a rough circle, burning low and steady in a clearing that the forest has grown around and away from, like the trees decided to leave this space alone. Shapes moving between the fires — some upright, some not, none of them quite right in a way Marcus has learned to recognize.

The pack.

He has found them before they found him. The compass is pointing directly at the center of the clearing where the largest fire burns.

PATH 2 — Marie's Information

Requires MARIE_FORMALLY_MET + TRUST_MARIE *6+* + MARIE_ATTACKED

After the attack on Day 16 Marie begins tracking the pack through the swamp's connection to the north woods. On Day 18 or later she calls Marcus to the swamp at night.

She draws in the dirt beside her fire. The pack's circuit — where they move, when, which trails they use. A map built from five nights of watching from the water and the willows.

"Their camp is here," she says, marking a point. *"They return to it before dawn. If you want to observe without being seen — go here, two hours before sunrise."*

She looks at Marcus.

"You are going to see something that will be difficult," she says. *"Remember what you are."*

She does not explain what she means. She goes inside.

PATH 3 — Investigation

Requires PACK_TRAIL_FOUND + SMOKE_IN_NORTH_WOODS + SCENT_TRAIL *ability*

Five visits to the north road. The maintained trail. The smoke. Marcus's Scent Trail ability following a specific track — the freshest one, the one that goes deepest. It takes three nights of following before the trail stops at the rise above the pack's clearing.

Each night he gets closer he feels the pull strengthen — not Marie's pull, not the hunger exactly. The pack's pull. The bond between infected calling to infected. His wolf recognizes the frequency.

THE PACK CLEARING — First Observation

Marcus observes from the rise without being detected. What he sees:

The clearing holds approximately fourteen figures — some human in posture, some not, several moving between states with the particular fluidity of people who have stopped finding the transition remarkable. Fires burning. Movement that has the quality of routine — this is not an encampment, it is a home. They have been here a long time.

At the center fire, apart from the others — three figures that hold themselves differently. Deliberate. Still. The lieutenants.

One of them Marcus recognizes.

Not the shape — the shape is wrong, larger than he remembers, differently balanced. But the angle of the head. The slight lean to the left. The way the hands hang.

Curtis.

CURTIS_LOCATED set PACK_CAMP_FOUND set

WHAT MARCUS OBSERVES

The pack is not feral. That is the first and most unsettling revelation. They communicate — not in ways Marcus can fully follow from the rise, but in ways that have structure. There is hierarchy. There is decision-making. The three lieutenants confer. The pack body responds.

And at the edge of the firelight — not sitting at the fires, not moving with the others — a shape that makes the fires seem small.

Cord.

He is not doing anything. He is simply present — the way a fact is present, the way a landform is present. His pale eyes catch the firelight and return nothing. He is looking at something in the middle distance that isn't there or isn't visible.

Then, without apparent cause, he turns and looks directly at the rise where Marcus is standing.

Marcus does not move. Does not breathe.

Cord looks at him for a long moment.

Then he looks away.

CORD_SEEN set CORD_KNOWS_MARCUS_IS_HERE set — he knew before Marcus crested the rise. He let Marcus watch.

NIGHT 20 — CURTIS

> *Automatic trigger. If Marcus is anywhere in the north woods on Night 20 Curtis finds him. If Marcus is not in the north woods — Curtis comes to the edge of the swamp path. He does not enter Marie's territory. He waits.*

The night is quiet in the wrong way — the pack's quiet, the forest holding its breath. Marcus is in the north woods or at the swamp's edge when he hears something that isn't a footstep and isn't an animal.

He turns.

Curtis is standing twenty feet away.

SEEING CURTIS

He is not the Curtis from the car. He is not the shadow from the full moon night. He is something between those things — larger than Marcus remembers, differently built, but standing upright and still with his arms at his sides and looking at Marcus with eyes that are Curtis's eyes even though the rest of him is negotiating between what it was and what it's becoming.

He is wearing different clothes. The brown corduroy jacket is gone — that's still in the tree on the north road. What he's wearing now is rougher, worn, practical. Pack clothes.

He looks at Marcus.

"Hey," he says.

His voice is the same. That's the part Marcus wasn't ready for. The voice is exactly the same.

THE CONVERSATION — What Curtis Tells You

He doesn't apologize. Marcus should notice that. He explains.

PART 1 — Why He Did It

"I know you're angry," Curtis says. *"I know what I did to you. I've been carrying that."*

He sits down on a root. It's such a Curtis thing to do — find somewhere to sit in the middle of a conversation that should be standing up for — that it hits Marcus somewhere specific.

"I was looking for the pack for six months before that night. I found out about them through a man in Meridian — he'd heard things, third-hand, rumors about the north woods outside some town nobody'd heard of." He looks at his hands. *"I was going to make contact. Join voluntarily. I had it planned."*

"The job was cover," Marcus says. Or doesn't say. Either way Curtis confirms it.

"The job was cover. I just needed to get to that road."

A long silence.

"You weren't supposed to get out of the car."

PART 2 — Why He Wanted This

> *This is the gut punch. Assembled across the entire game, delivered here in Curtis's own voice.*

"You know what it's like," he says, *"being exactly as far as you're ever going to get? You do the jobs. You watch the men giving the orders. You know you're smarter than half of them and it doesn't matter — it is never going to matter — because of what you are and where you came from and what year it is."*

He looks north toward the pack's clearing.

"Out here — in this — I'm working my way up. Three weeks and they still look at me like I don't belong." Something in his voice. Not pride — determination. The determination of a man who has bet everything on a door that hasn't fully opened yet. *"But I'm close. I can feel it. Cord's watching me."*

He looks at Marcus.

"I know how that sounds."

[Player reads this in silence. No choice yet. This lands without interruption."]

PART 3 — What's Been Happening

"The disappearances — that was Cord's call. He's building toward something. The next full moon." Curtis looks north again. His expression changes slightly when he looks toward Cord's location — not fear, not quite. Orientation. *"He wants the numbers. Sixteen is what he's been building toward since — since a long time. Something about the threshold. Something about what sixteen means on this land."*

He looks at Marcus.

"You were supposed to be sixteen. That's why you're still here and still you. Cord's been patient with you because you're meant to complete the count."

A beat.

"He knows about the compass. He knows you've been in the woods. He's been watching you since Day 1."

CORD_AGENDA_KNOWN set — sixteen infected on the threshold land for the next full moon. What that does, what it unlocks, is not something Curtis knows. Takoda does.

PART 4 — The Watch

Marcus can ask about the watch if CURTIS_WATCH_FOUND.

Curtis is quiet for a moment.

"I put it there so you'd know I was sorry," he says. *"Not for what happened to you — I can't undo that. For leaving without saying anything."*

He looks at the ground.

"For making that choice and not letting you make yours."

HUMANITY +10 — hearing the truth, even this truth, is human.

THE CHOICE — Attack or Listen

After everything Curtis has said, Marcus has a choice.

OPTION A — ATTACK CURTIS

"Everything you just told me — and you think that's enough?"

Marcus moves.

COMBAT — MARCUS VS CURTIS

Curtis is a lieutenant. He has been in the pack for weeks. He is stronger than Marcus currently and more practiced with what they both are.

Stat	Marcus	Curtis
HP	Current HEALTH	75
Attack Mod	Current stage	+5
Defense	Current	16
Damage	Current die	d10
Special	Pack Sense, Lupine abilities	**Alpha Bond** — Cord is aware of this fight. If Curtis drops below 30 HP the pack begins moving toward this location.

> *This is the hardest fight in the game to this point. Marcus can win — but it requires full use of every ability built across eighteen days. Using lupine abilities here does NOT cost HUMANITY — this is wolf fighting wolf, the wolf's natural context.*

COMBAT RESOLUTION — MARCUS WINS

Curtis is on the ground. Breathing. Beaten but alive — Marcus pulled back at the end, or the wolf pulled back at the end, or something did.

They are both still for a moment.

Curtis looks up at him.

"You win," he says. Just that.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Curtis's fate]

A1 — "Get up. You're done with them." Curtis laughs — a short, painful sound. *"Marcus."* He looks at the north woods. *"I can't go back. I don't want to go back."* A long silence. *"Then what do I do with you?" "Let me go back to them,"* Curtis says. *"As a beta. I step down. You take the lieutenant position."* He meets Marcus's eyes. *"It's the only way both of us walk out of these woods."* CURTIS_BETA set. PACK_MEMBERSHIP_OFFERED set. Marcus has beaten a lieutenant. The pack knows. Cord is watching. An invitation is now open.

A2 — "It's over, Curtis." The hardest three words in the game. Curtis looks at Marcus for a long time. Something in his face — the part that is still Curtis, still the man from the car — understands. *"Yeah,"* he says quietly. *"Okay."* What happens next is between them. The game cuts away. CURTIS_DEAD set. PACK_DISRUPTED set — the pack has lost a lieutenant. Cord is aware. The pack membership path is still open — defeating a lieutenant is sufficient — but the cost of it will sit differently now. HUMANITY -15. RAGE -20. The wolf is satisfied. Marcus is not.

OPTION B — LISTEN

Marcus doesn't attack.

He sits down across from Curtis in the dark north woods and they talk for a long time. Two men from the same nowhere, arrived at the same impossible place from different directions.

When it's done Curtis stands.

"Come back tomorrow night," he says. *"I'll bring you in front of Cord."*

CURTIS_ALIVE_ALLIED set. PACK_INTRO_OFFERED set. This is the diplomatic path to pack membership — no combat required. Curtis sponsors Marcus directly.

JOINING THE PACK

> *Available via either path — combat victory (Curtis beta or dead) or Curtis's sponsorship.*

Marcus enters the pack clearing for the first time not as an observer but as a presence. The pack registers him — some with wariness, some with the particular attention of creatures who recognize a new element in their established order.

Cord does not greet him. Cord doesn't move. His pale eyes track Marcus from the large fire and that is the extent of the acknowledgment.

Curtis (if alive) stands with Marcus. If dead — the three remaining lieutenants assess Marcus with the particular attention of people recalculating hierarchy.

Marcus is pack. Not fully — not until the full moon, not until the threshold ritual Cord is building toward. But accepted. Present. Inside the circle of fires rather than above it on the rise.

PACK_MEMBER set **Stat Effect:** HUMANITY -10, RAGE -15 — the pack quiets the wolf in ways Marcus couldn't manage alone. The cost is what it costs.

MEETING CORD — The Kidnapping

> *Cord will not acknowledge Marcus directly until Marcus has participated in a successful pack attack. The first assigned attack: kidnap either Calhoun or Pruitt depending on prior flags.*

THE TARGET

IF CALHOUN_ALIVE (not killed in CHAINS or by Jacob): The pack has watched Aldous Calhoun for five years. They know about the root cellar. They know about the chains. They know what happened to Jacob Marsh. Cord's selection of Calhoun is not random — it is the oldest outstanding business on this land. The man who chained things and waited for them to die will now be chained and waited upon himself.

IF CALHOUN_DEAD (killed in CHAINS ending or by Jacob): The target is **Sheriff Ray Pruitt.** Cord is pragmatic — the town's authority structure must be disrupted before the full moon. Pruitt represents order. Remove order. The pack moves into the resulting vacuum.

THE ATTACK — Night 21+

The pack moves at midnight. Fluid, coordinated, silent in the way of things that have been doing this for over a century. Marcus moves with them and the wolf in him finds the pack's rhythm immediately — it has been trying to find this frequency since Day 1 without knowing what it was reaching for.

They take their target from a specific location — Calhoun leaving the feed store late, or Pruitt doing his evening perimeter walk. The attack is fast, professional, overwhelming. Marcus's role is specific: get in position, create the opening, fall back. The lieutenants do the rest.

The target is taken alive. Cord wants them alive.

They are brought to the clearing. Bound. Conscious.

Marcus stands in the firelight with the pack around him and the target at his feet and Cord finally moves.

CORD — FIRST DIRECT ENCOUNTER

He walks from the large fire toward Marcus with the particular gait of something that has been walking this land for over a century and no longer notices the ground.

Up close he is—

He is General Silas Cord. Even now. Even after all of it. The bearing is military — erect, deliberate, the unconscious posture of someone who gave orders and had them followed. The uniform is long gone but the shape of the man who wore it is still there underneath everything the spirit made of him. He is large in a way that has nothing to do with physical size. He is old in a way that has nothing to do with years.

His eyes are the pale blue-gray Marcus saw from the rise. Up close they are the eyes of a man who remembers everything — who has been remembering everything for a hundred years — and has organized all of that memory into a single coherent purpose.

He looks at Marcus.

He does not speak immediately. He examines Marcus the way a commanding officer examines a new addition to his unit — assessing, categorizing, determining utility.

Then:

"You took longer than expected," he says.

His voice is the voice of a Virginia planter's son educated at West Point. It has not changed in a hundred years. It is the most disorienting thing about him.

"I've been watching you since the field," he says. *"Watching you resist. Watching you investigate. Watching you build relationships and gather information like a man trying to solve a problem."* He tilts his head slightly. *"The problem is not solvable the way you were approaching it."*

He looks at the bound target. Then back at Marcus.

"This is the approach that works," he says. *"Strength. Clarity of purpose. The removal of obstacles."*

He extends his hand.

Not for a handshake. Palm down, slightly — the gesture of a commanding officer acknowledging a new subordinate.

[PLAYER CHOICE — Take it or stand your ground]

Take it: CORD_ACKNOWLEDGED_MARCUS set. The pack registers the exchange. Marcus is no longer probationary — he is recognized. HUMANITY -10. Something closes in him that he won't be able to reopen easily.

Stand your ground: Cord looks at Marcus for a long moment. Something in his expression that might be respect — the first flicker of it. *"Good,"* he says. *"You'll need that."* He walks away. CORD_RESPECTS_RESISTANCE set — Marcus is pack but not subordinate. The rarest position in this clearing.

MARIE FINDS OUT — The Morning After

She doesn't come to Marcus. He goes to her — or tries to. The swamp path is open. Her fire is visible.

She is sitting where she always sits. She looks at Marcus when he appears on the path.

She looks at him for a long time.

She says nothing.

She stands up and goes inside.

The door does not close — there is no door, there has never been a door on that cabin, the opening has always just been an opening. But something closes. Marcus can feel it the way he felt the pull on Night 18 — in reverse. A frequency going quiet.

If Marcus calls after her:

She stops. Does not turn.

"I told you to remember what you are," she says. *"When you went to those woods."*

"Marie—"

"I know what you did," she says. *"I know whose company you keep now."* A pause so long Marcus thinks she's done. *"You had a choice about what kind of man you were going to be in this place. You made it."*

She goes inside.

MARIE_WITHDRAWN set — Marie is no longer accessible for regular conversation. The trust thread, the housing option if not yet taken, the lore she hadn't shared yet — all of it locked.

Stat Effect: HUMANITY -10 — her silence costs more than she said.

> *Marie will re-engage only under two conditions: 1. Marcus leaves the pack and takes significant action to demonstrate it 2. Night 18 — GODDESS OF VOODOO thread (she comes regardless)*

HATTIE — THE SAME MORNING

> *Only relevant if HATTIE_ALIVE*

Hattie is at the front desk when Marcus comes in. She looks up. She reads something in his face — she has been reading faces across this counter for thirty years — and whatever she reads makes her go still for a moment.

She doesn't ask.

She pours him coffee. Sets it on the counter. Goes back to her ledger.

After a while, without looking up:

"Ray Pruitt usually comes by in the morning," she says. *"Checks on things. Gets coffee."*

She turns a page.

"He didn't come this morning."

She doesn't say anything else about it. She doesn't need to.

HATTIE_KNOWS_SOMETHING_WRONG set — she won't confront Marcus. She won't report him. She will carry this the way she has carried everything about this town — quietly, practically, at significant personal cost.

IF PRUITT_TAKEN: By Day 22 Hattie will ask Marcus directly if he's seen the sheriff. Her voice is careful and her eyes are not.

[PLAYER CHOICE]

- **Lie:** She nods. Sets down her pen. *"Alright."* She doesn't believe it. HUMANITY -5.
- **Say nothing:** She looks at him for a long time. Then she picks her pen back up. HUMANITY -10 — the silence is its own answer and they both know it.
- **Tell her:** HUMANITY +5 — the truth costs something but the lie costs more. What Hattie does with the information depends on PRUITT_REL and what flags are set. She may go to someone. She may not. She is a woman who has survived Wroughtwood this long by knowing when to speak and when the speaking would only make things worse.

SCENE NOTES

- **Curtis finding the ceiling higher in the pack** is the most honest thing he says and the most damning. He's not wrong that the world has a ceiling for men like them in 1960. He found a way around it. That the way around it required becoming something that kidnaps people and serves a century-old general is the part he's organized himself not to examine too closely.
- **Cord's West Point voice** is intentional and should never be commented on in the text — just presented. A commanding officer's voice coming out of something that has been in the north woods for a hundred years. The player sits with that.
- **"You took longer than expected"** — Cord has been waiting for Marcus specifically. Not because Marcus is special. Because sixteen is the number and the timing of the next full moon is fixed and Marcus is the piece that completes the count. He is patient because he has always been patient.
- **Marie going inside without closing a door** is the right image. There's no door to close. The closing is in the frequency, in the pull going quiet. Marcus knows exactly what he lost and has to stand on that path and feel it.
- **Hattie noting the missing morning visit** is Wroughtwood doing what Wroughtwood does — absorbing violence quietly, noting the absence, carrying on. The town has been doing this for a hundred years. It knows how.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
CURTIS_LOCATED	Pack camp found
PACK_CAMP_FOUND	Any entry path
CORD_SEEN	First observation from rise
CORD_KNOWS_MARCUS_IS_HERE	First observation
CORD_AGENDA_KNOWN	Curtis conversation Part 3
CURTIS_BETA	Attack path, Curtis spared as beta
CURTIS_DEAD	Attack path, Curtis killed
CURTIS_ALIVE_ALLIED	Listen path
PACK_MEMBER	Joining the pack
CORD_ACKNOWLEDGED_MARCUS	Cord's hand taken
CORD_RESPECTS_RESISTANCE	Cord's hand refused
MARIE_WITHDRAWN	Morning after pack join
HATTIE_KNOWS_SOMETHING_WRONG	Morning after
CALHOUN_TAKEN	Kidnap Calhoun
PRUITT_TAKEN	Kidnap Pruitt